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Lost Islands Cruise

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[Continued from Vol.5(4), 1991]

MANGAREVA

From the blustery and cool south Pacific and the fog shrouded pinnacles of Morotiri, the *Society Discoverer* sailed north and east toward Mangareva. We caught sight of Mangareva's peaks at sun-up, and soon navigated over the surrounding reef and into the immense lagoon. Mangareva ("floating mountain"), one of the Gambier Islands, is just north of the Tropic of Capricorn, and 1650 km southeast of Tahiti. Ten rocky islands make up a grand total of 22 sq.km of dry land. Formerly forested, it is now mostly covered with *aeho* grass. In earlier days the island was a pearl fishing center.

Archaeological excavations in Mangareva were carried out by Roger Green in 1959. The material culture suggests a relationship with the Marquesas and it is believed that these islands were settled around AD 1100; at present, the earliest date for Mangareva is A.D. 1200. Working here in 1970, Yosi Sinoto found pearl-shell fishhooks like those of Henderson and the early Marquesas. It is likely that Mangareva was the jumping off place for Pitcairn and Henderson.

One of the isles in the lagoon is called Agakauitai, and it is notable for a cliffside cave said to contain the remains of 35 generations of cannibal kings.

Our ship headed for the tiny village of Rikitea, stretched out along the beach. We disembarked on a long jetty and were surprised to see cement roads and French soldiers with army equipment. Things have certainly changed here since Bill Mulloy visited the island in 1956. As he wrote home to his family:

"This was really our first Polynesian island of the classic movie type, with grass houses and the natives running around in pareus....the classic Polynesian scene. In early days the island was a pearl fishing center and with a population of several thousand people...All over the island are the ruins of large stone houses formerly occupied by rich Frenchmen and now covered with jungle. Now sometimes in the yards of

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More Journals On Easter Island: The works of Johann Reinhold Forster (1729-1798) and Johann George Adam Forster (1754-1794)

Herbert von Saher

Previous publications on the details of the discovery of Easter Island, as taken from the Journals of Roggeveen (RNJ 4(3) and of Bouman (RNJ 4(4), have aroused the interest of many readers. This article continues in the same vein, concentrating on a visit to Easter Island by Captain James Cook in March 1774. Much has been written in the English language about Cook's visit but little attention has been given to publications in German, although these are of the greatest importance, not only in themselves, but also because they inspired and influenced later scientists such as Alexander von Humboldt and even Charles Darwin. The Forsters, who wrote the following descriptions, were father and son; Johann George (always called George) was the eldest son of Johann Forster.

"Among Captain James Cook's three great voyages of discovery none has aroused so much literary, scientific and editorial controversy and speculation, contemporarily or later, as the second undertaken between 1772 and 1775. Most of the animus and controversy has surrounded, directly or indirectly, the life, person and work of ....Johann Reinhold Forster, principal naturalist of the voyage. The disputes have been intensely personal as well as scientific and 'philosophical'." Thus begins the preface to Michael E. Hoare's book, *The Resolution Journal of Johann Reinhold Forster, 1772-1775* (Hakluyt Society, London 1982).

The controversial Johann Reinhold Forster was the son of the burgomaster of the City of Danzig, descendants of a Yorkshire family which had fled from England for political reasons in the 1640s. After finishing the famous Joachimsthal-Gymnasium in Berlin in 1728, Johann began--at the insistence of his father-- to study theology at the University of Halle (Johann had preferred to study medicine). He was ordained in 1751 and returned to Danzig to preach. In 1765 he left for Russia with his son George (then 11 years old). Johann had been engaged by Empress Catharina the Great to make a survey on the conditions of the colonies of German settlers along the Volga River--one

of her pet projects. His report stated that the many complaints of the settlers were justified and, as a result of this frankness, his contract was not prolonged and father and son returned to Danzig, without being paid for the 14 months of work.

Forster did not relish returning to his post in Danzig, so he went to London with son George, leaving the rest of the family behind. They supported themselves at first by selling artifacts collected on their Russian expedition. By this time, Johann had mastered 17 languages, was learned in philology, ancient geography, and natural history. In short, he was an 18th century man of scholarship but, as is often the case with men of genius, he was a difficult character who created conflicts around him.

Science and letters were Johann's passport to employment and recognition in London. He gave a lecture for the Society of Antiquaries and was elected as an Honorary Fellow in 1767. In financial difficulty, he accepted the post of tutor at Warrington Academy, noted for its liberal education. George, then aged 13, was left in London as an apprentice in a merchant firm where his language skills were already a useful asset in foreign trade. The rest of the family then came from Danzig, and eventually George also came to Warrington to become a student. While at Warrington, Johann published many scientific papers and established himself as a leading naturalist.

Controversies at Warrington led Johann to leave; he taught elsewhere, became an Inspector of the Royal Society's Museum, and began soliciting to participate in Cook's second journey to the Pacific.

Joseph Banks, the naturalist on Cook's first journey and earmarked as such for the second one, had built on so many extra works on the deck of the *Resolution* for his scientific equipment that the ship was no longer seaworthy. The Admiralty ordered the deck to be shorn back to normal; when Banks heard this, a big row ensued and Banks appealed directly to the King. In the meantime, Forster was being considered as a replacement. He had only two conditions: that provision be made for his family and George (then 18) be allowed to accompany him as an assistant. In June, the King decided against Banks and two weeks later the Forsters were ready to leave for three years. The ship sailed on the 13th of July 1772.

As if by magic, Johann had, for the first time, a job that matched his capacities as well as his pretensions--a job he executed in a splendid way. However, controversies arose as the result of the inflexible positions he took, and we shall see that proper recognition of his work became impossible for another 200 years.

Lord Sandwich, the First Lord of the Admiralty, had nominated William Wales as astronomer to observe an eclipse of the sun while in the Southern Hemisphere and William Hodges as painter, specifying the responsibilities of each; but for Forster, no clear written instructions were given. No instructions were given to any of these men about reporting on their findings.

After his return, Johann began working on his Journal, supposing that each scientist would individually present a paper on his particular subject, to be added to Cook's report. But after Johann presented a draft, it appeared that this was not the intent of the Admiralty. Instead they were to sign an agreement on a "joint narrative" to be edited by a person who had not even made the voyage. Johann refused to submit to a "censor", and offered his manuscript to the government, which refused it. The controversy became so heated that Johann was forbidden to publish his manuscript.

It was at this point that George (then 22) wrote a book, as the interdiction of the Admiralty did not affect him. Nine months later, George's *Entdeckungsreise nach Tahiti und in die Sudsee, 1772-1775*, translated into English as *A Voyage round the World* (London, 1777) came out. It was an immediate success.

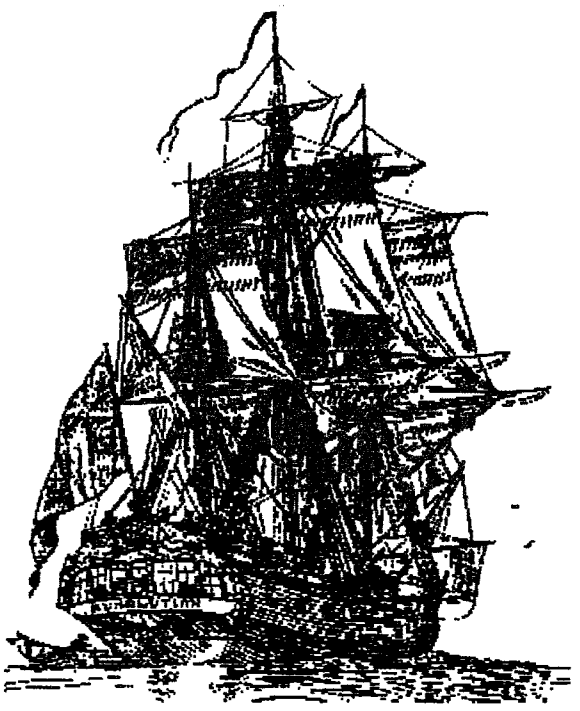
It has been suggested that George used his father's diary as a basis for the book, but at that moment there was no proof of this. What is certain is that George stole the limelight; he was called the "creator of artistic travel literature in the German language", and rightly so. Johann's diary was not published, and disappeared from view.

Johann died in 1798 and his wife sold his library to pay debts. In cataloging the 7000 volumes, the manuscript of the *Resolution* was not mentioned but there were items described as "one drawer full of unbound books" and another "unbound books of natural history", etc. that could mean anything. This library eventually came to rest in the Staatsbibliothek der Stiftung Preussischer Kulturbesitz in a part of Berlin that was, until a short time ago, Eastern Germany.

It was only in the 1970s that some researchers, dissatisfied with the fact that the original notes of Johann Forster had not been found, went to the library in East Berlin and began to look into these "drawers full of unbound books". There they found the manuscript, uncataloged and undiscovered for 200 years! It was even written in English. It was published by Hoare in the 1982 edition of the Hakluyt Society of London and is of the utmost importance for it reveals that it was indeed father Johann's notes that were the basis for George's *Voyage round the World.*

Johann's notes identify and describe about 500 new plants and 300 new animals, particularly birds, a scientific achievement perhaps never surpassed in such great numbers. Moreover, Johann's descriptions are of great ethnological, anthropological, mineralogical, and philological importance. The Forsters were the first to note the parallels between the different Polynesian languages, now described as belonging to the Austronesian family.

I have read both George's *Voyage*...and Johann's journal, so I can compare the two. It should be stated that such



H.M.S. Resolution

comparisons are unfair because the diary of the father contains notes made daily on the spot--sometimes in tropical rain on the equator, sometimes with frosty fingers beyond the Polar circle. They contain weather reports, sea conditions, temperature, position of the ship on the ocean (and the problems in fixing it), the miles sailed each day, and when on land, the number of animals shot, stuffed, species identified, new species noted (along with doubts whether or not it should be a different one). This is all of great scientific interest but for the general public, it makes for dull reading. Often Johann goes into longer argumentation on a particular subject that has caught his attention, such as his emphatic defense of the eating of sauerkraut to prevent scurvy (the crew must have hated him for this enforced diet of sauerkraut but this trip was made with an exceptionally low loss of life--none by the dreaded scurvy).

George's book, written with the benefit of hindsight over the whole three year trip, eliminates dull statistics and the day-to-day entries. To the more factual data of Johann's diary, George has added impressions from his own memory,and these are a delight to the reader. For George was very much a child of the age (*Aufklarung*: enlightenment) in the second half of the 18th century: a movement that wished to respect human beings, that was sensitive to the idea of "noble savages" and longed for a return to nature. These ideas of equality, fraternity and human dignity were to inspire those who brought about the French revolution. Despite George's pleasant, fluent style and keen eye for observation, he never forgets the human touch and often becomes quite poetic. These characteristics made his book famous, at least to German readers.

For the non-scientific reader, George's *Voyage...* is therefore much preferable to read. In this paper, we shall give a report on the Forster's visit to Easter Island in March 1774. But before that depressing event, we will begin with a few passages from earlier visits they made to Tahiti, for their experiences there were more idyllic and George Forster's style can best be seen in his descriptions of this earthly paradise.

Exerpts from the chapter on Tahiti: It was on a morning, more beautiful than a poet could describe, that we saw the island of Tahiti at two miles distance. The easterly wind had gone down and a slight sigh from land brought us the most refreshing and beautifully scented air that lightly touched the surface of the sea. Forested mountains lifted their proud peaks in many majestic forms and glowed in the first rays of the sun. Underneath those were lower, slightly undulating hills, also covered with forest in different tones of green...and in front was the plain shaded by breadfruit trees and innumerable palms whose lofty tops emerged high above them. Everything seemed in a deep slumber, with the morning hardly started; silent shadows hovered about the land. Slowly one could see houses under the trees and canoes drawn up on the beach. Half a mile from shore was a line of reefs running parallel to the coast and over these the sea broke in a foaming surf. But behind this the water was like a mirror, promising the safest anchoring site. The sun lighted up the plain; the inhabitants awoke and our view came to life.

Hardly had our big ships been discovered off the coast when some people ran to the beach, pushed their canoes into the water and paddled towards us. It did not take them long to go through the reef opening and one came so near to us that we could shout to them. Two nearly naked men wearing a sort of turban on their heads and a cloth around their loins waved a large green leaf and called out "*tayo*", an exclaimation we could without trouble and the use of dictionaries interpret as a greeting of friendship.....We lowered presents of beads, nails and medals; they offered us a young green banana shoot (a symbol of peace) and asked us to attach it to the rigging so that all could see it.

Within the hour we were surrounded by hundreds of boats that carried one to four persons. They trusted us so much that they all came unarmed and from all sides the greeting of "*tayo*" sounded and we reciprocated with joy. They brought coconuts, bananas, breadfruit and other fruits that were traded for glass beads and small nails. This multitude of canoes was a beautiful sight, a sort of market on the water. I traded through my porthole and in half an hour I had already

collected three unknown kinds of birds and a large number of new fish. The color of the fishes was, as long as they lived, of an exceptional beauty and I used that same morning to draw them and indicate their colors before these disappeared with their lives.

The people that surrounded us had gentle traits and nice behavior....we considered the development of these people more advanced than any others we had seen up to now. Both sexes wore the black tattoo marks, created by puncturing the skin and rubbing the wounds with black paint.

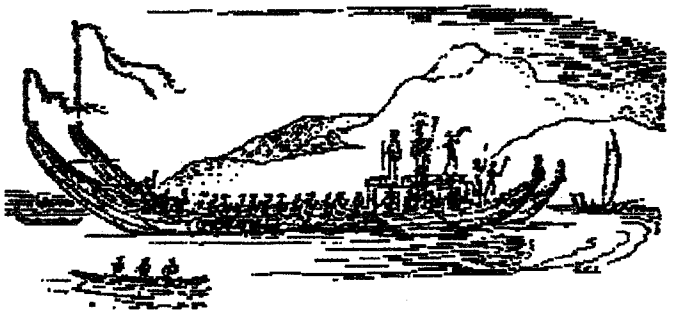
It did not take long before several of them came on board. Their usually gentle nature, one of their main characteristics, appeared from all their gestures and acts and it gave everyone who studies the human heart cause for reflection. The signs of their approach were of diverse nature; some took our hands, others leaned on our shoulders, others embraced us. At the same time they admired the white color of our skins and sometimes took the clothes from our breasts as if they wanted to verify that we had been created like them.

A big canoe came alongside our ship with a handsome well-built man in it, accompanied by three women. They all came on board and the man, who seemed to be of some importance, said he was called O Tai. Of the three women, one was his wife and the others his sisters. They enjoyed teaching us how to call their names; one was Maroya and the other Marorai. The latter had a gracious figure and the upper part of her body was exceptionally beautiful. She had an agreeable face and a broad smile. None had been on board a ship before and admired everything they found. And not only on deck, but they also let themselves be invited into the cabins of the officers. Morarai very much liked some of the bedclothes and tried to get them as a present from her companion. He was willing but required in compensation a special favor to which Morarai could not initially agree. When she saw that no other means were successful, she gave in. Her companion, prepared to enjoy his victory, was inconveniently interrupted when the ship struck a rock. the frightened lover hurried on deck where all were at their posts, bringing out another anchor to draw the ship away from the reef. They succeeded in escaping from great danger, but when the officer returned to his cabin, the bedclothes and Morarai were gone.

On their second visit to Tahiti, eight months later, old friends were met again and Cook's men were greatly impressed by a sight they had not seen before.

When we arrived at the coast of O-Parre we were surprised by an unexpected sight : all along the beach was a great fleet of war canoes at anchor, manned with paddlers and warriors in complete outfit with breastshields and high helmets. Despite a beach full of people, an expectant silence was maintained. We had hardly gone on shore when the commander of the fleet hurried to meet us. He went to our captain and shook hands, calling him "friend". We inspected the ships, all of which were facing land. There were no less than 159 double war canoes of 50 to 60 feet in length, the hulls joined by 15 to 18 strong beams. When one realizes the imperfection of their tools, one cannot but admire the patience with which these ships must have been constructed. In felling trees, sawing planks from them, planing them smooth, joining them, and finally assembling them, they have nothing more than a stone axe and chisel, a piece of coral, and some sharkskin for the final polishing.

Each vessel had about 15 to 20 warriors. Their clothing was marvelous and made the greatest impression. They had on three big dresses with a hole for the head; the inner was white, the second red, and the outer (and shortest one) was brown. Breastplates were adorned with feathers and sharks teeth. Their helmet were nearly five feet high, made from a long basket, the front of which had been enforced by additional wickerwork. Along the edges were tail feathers of tropical birds which stood out like rays so that from a distance it appeared as if a circle of light radiated out around the warrior's head. Principal commanders wore a distinctive sign that looked a bit like the "horsetails" of Turkish pashas. It consisted of long tails hanging down the back with green and yellow feathers.



Tahitian canoes as drawn by the Resolution's artist

In order to see the fleet from the sea side, we rowed along the whole line of canoes. In each was a bundle of spears and long combat-axes; each warrior had a spear or axe in his hand. Canoes also had a heap of big stones for throwing at the enemy. Apart from war canoes, we counted another 70 small roofed canoes for the night rest of the commanders or for stocking food. Others were filled with banana leaves, for carrying corpses. A modest estimation of the total manning of this fleet is 1500 warriors and 4000 paddlers.

This impressive fleet was assembled to suppress a rebellion on the island of Eimeo. Cook offered to follow the fleet and fire a few cannonshots at the offending island "for fun" but the commander came back with the reply that his fleet was not ready to attack and this will only be the case when Cook has left Tahiti. Nearing final departure, the *Resolution* gives a nightly demonstration with rockets and fireworks, and then

they sail away, giving volleys with their cannons in a final salute.

George's final conclusions are prophetic. He may have been the first to use the words "human rights": "On all occasions the lower classes of Tahiti show so much love towards the higher caste that it seems that they see themselves as one single family and their commanders as their elder brothers having a preference according to the right of primogeniture. The lowest man is as free to speak to his King as with his equals and he can approach him when he wants. This would become difficult as soon as despotism would establish itself. The King also occupies himself in the same way as his subjects, still free from the false ideas of vain honour and empty privileges and he does not feel ashamed at all to take the rudder of his canoe in his own hand. It is difficult to indicate how long this happy equality will last, but given the laziness of the upper class it will not last forever. Up to now the field work that the lowest caste has to execute is not too heavy, but as the upperclass that have no work at all to do, will multiply at a much higher rate, the serving class will be ever more heavily loaded with work and suffer the negative results of this. This will diminish the energy of the lower class, the obligation to work in the burning sun will blacken their skins and as a result of the frequent and early debaucheries of their daughters with the upper classes, they will finally denigrate into small, dwarflike creatures. Contrary to this, the easy going upper class will have the advantages of greater height, a better education and a lighter colour of skin because they alone can follow their gluttonous appetite without limit and live in carefree idleness. Finally the lower class will suffer under this pressure and realize its causes, then the feeling of violated human rights will awaken in them and cause a revolution. This is the normal course of history for all nations. For Tahiti it will still take a long time before such a change can be foreseen, but the possibility that the import of foreign luxury might accelerate the arrival of this unhappy period, is a point that one should present to the Europeans for serious consideration. Really, when science and knowledge for individual people have to be established at the expense of whole nations, it would be better for the explorers as well as the explored if the Pacific had forever remained unknown to those restless Europeans."

George ends his Tahiti section with such a lyrical description of the beauty of the island, the extreme beauty of the people and the incredible excellence of life on this island that a present-day tour operator would pay a fortune for such copy. I abstain from further detail and from making this article too long for two reasons: to stimulate Rapanuiphiles to get a copy of the whole book which contains so many literary jewels, and now the reader must be prepared for a less enraptured description of Easter Island--which is, finally, the object of this article.

.....to be continued in the next issue

Lost Islands Cruise

.....continued from page 1

these old plantations are the grass houses of the natives who have completely reverted to the native way of life."

Mulloy would not recognize Rikitea today. Although the old ruins are still visible and still covered with jungle, now the islanders live in stucco houses with tin roofs and flowery curtains.

Father Honore Laval of the Order of Picpus, a half-sane French priest, ruled here for almost 40 years and managed to completely destroy the native culture. Arriving in 1834, he toppled effigies and dismantled *marae* for stone to build a cathedral, imposed a ruthless moral code on the islanders and treated them as virtual slaves in order to construct a 1200 seat church, convents, and triumphal arches. The island population dropped from 9000 to 500 during Laval's unconscionable reign. His architectural monument, the massive blue and white cathedral of St. Michel, represents an improbable memorial to egomania; the twin towers of white coral rock can be seen for miles. The interior is lavishly decorated with mother-of-pearl, hanging chandeliers, and six foot silver candlesticks.

Mangareva's cathedral remains as a bitter memory and legacy of Laval's cruel reign on the island.

Laval also built a huge convent high on an inland hill; islanders say that once a woman was sent into a convent, the only way for her to leave was in a coffin.

Laval finally was taken away in 1871 to Tahiti, tried for murder and declared insane.

We walked up from the great blue and white cathedral to see the tomb of the last island king and then up to the convent's sad ruin, now reverting to jungle. Not far from here we noted the ruins of a *marae*, one that Laval must have